

THE ALLURE OF ILLUSION

VR today is a technology poised for widespread adoption. But why now? And how is your life going to change exactly?

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If science fiction is a representation of mankind's dreams and aspirations, it may hold important cues to our future. Take the concept of Virtual Reality. It has captivated those slightly more evolved amongst us ever since humanity started asking difficult questions about life, the nature of reality, and the allure of illusion. In fact, the dream of attaining VR has been right up there with space travel, artificial intelligence and immortality. Whether it was the idea of driving hoverbikes in Questworld or experiencing even a few moments in Star Trek's Holodeck, as children too we have always been fascinated by Virtual Reality. And why wouldn't it be fascinating? The promise of VR is too great to ignore. The possibility of putting on a pair of glasses and escaping the mundane, being transported into worlds of untold splendour in an instant, isn't just appealing, it's downright exhilarating!

One of the earliest efforts to make this dream of developing artificially generated sensory immersion a reality happened with the ironically (or aptly?) named Sword of Damocles head mounted display created by Ivan Sutherland in 1968. While working together with David Evans at the University of Utah they

created a simulator which was huge and clunky but served as a proof of concept. Though rudimentary, it worked. It gave users a genuine illusion of being in a virtual environment.

The decades that followed saw waning interest in the technology in the consumer space. VR head mounted displays or experience zones that did eventually

reach consumers were relegated to malls and arcades, still too expensive for them to be a household phenomenon. It's reported that at this time, VPL Research, one of the pioneering companies to actually build usable VR tech, sold its headsets for \$100,000 a pop. Naturally the technology only found takers in niche industries and as logic would suggest, so



Your gateway into the world of illusion